

Scale in Distributed Systems

Observation

Many developers of modern distributed systems easily use the adjective “scalable” without making clear **why** their system actually scales.

Scalability

At least three components:

- Number of users and/or processes ([size scalability](#))
 - Maximum distance between nodes ([geographical scalability](#))
 - Number of administrative domains ([administrative scalability](#))
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Observation

Most systems account only, to a certain extent, for size scalability. A (non)solution: powerful servers. Today, the challenge lies in geographical and administrative scalability.

Geographical scalability

Cannot simply go from LAN to WAN:

- Many distributed systems assume synchronous client-server interactions
- Client sends request and waits for an answer.
- Latency may easily prohibit this scheme.

WAN links are often inherently unreliable

- Simply moving streaming video from LAN to WAN will fail.

Lack of m commun

- A simple broadcast cannot be deployed
- Solution: Develop separate and direct services their own scalability problems

Administrative scalability

Essence: Conflicting policies concerning **usage** (and the payment), **management**, and **security**

Examples:

- **Computational grids:** share expensive resources between different domains.
- **Shared equipment:** how to control, manage, and use a shared radio telescope constructed as large-scale shared sensor network?

Exception: Several peer-to-peer networks

- **File-sharing systems** (based, e.g., on BitTorrent)
- **Peer-to-peer** telephony (Skype)
- **Peer-assisted** audio streaming (Spotify)

Note: **End users** collaborate and not **administrative entities**.

Size Scalability $A \rightarrow A$

- Root causes for scalability problems with centralized solutions

Computational capacity, limited by the CPUs

Storage capacity, including the transfer rate between CPUs and disks

Network between the user and the centralized service

Size Scaling Technique 1

Hide communication latencies

Avoid waiting for responses; do something else:

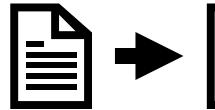
Make use of
**asynchronous
communication**

Have separate
handler for
incoming
response

Problem: not
every
application fits
this model

Size Scaling Technique 2

Replication/caching



Make copies of data available at different machines:

**Replicated file
servers and
databases**

**Mirrored Web
sites**

**Web caches
(in browsers
and proxies)**

**File caching
(at server and
client)**

Replication Problems

Observation

Applying scaling techniques is easy, except for one thing:

- Having multiple copies (cached or replicated), leads to **inconsistencies**: modifying one copy makes that copy different from the rest.
 - Always keeping copies consistent and in a general way requires **global synchronization** on each modification.
 - Global synchronization precludes large-scale solutions.
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Observation

If we can tolerate inconsistencies, we may reduce the need for global synchronization, but **tolerating inconsistencies is application dependent**.

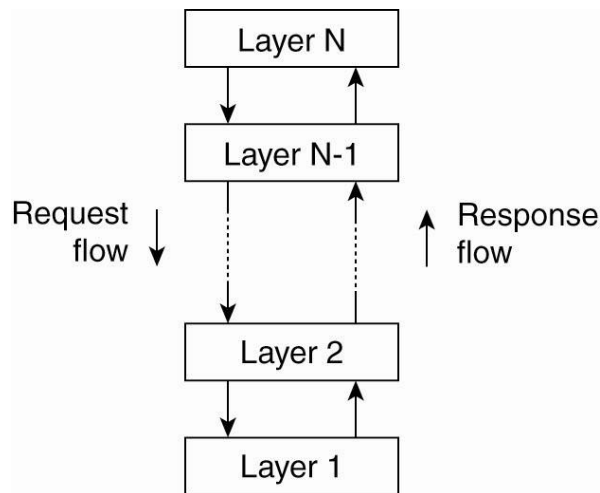
So Far

- Definitions and Goals
- Architectural Styles
- System Architectures
- Peer to Peer
- Edge Computing
- Blockchain basics

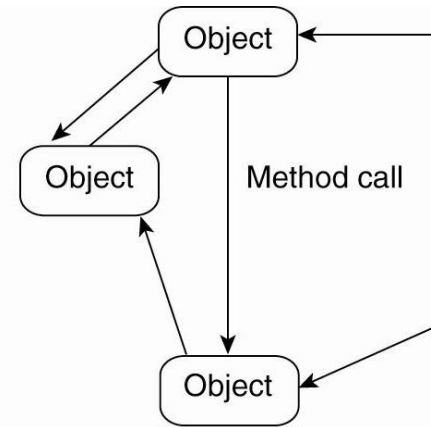
Architectural Styles

Basic Idea

Organize into logically different components and distribute those components over the various machines



(a)



(b)

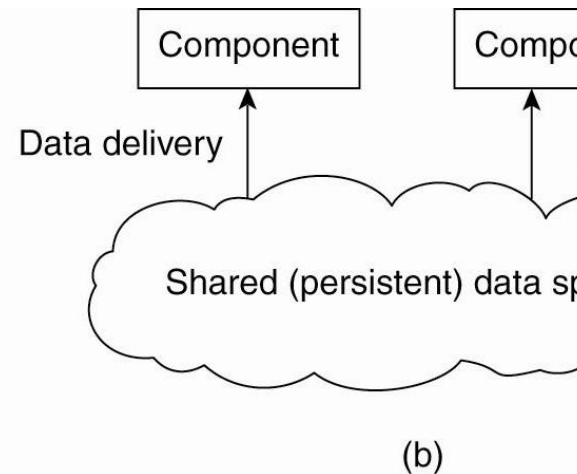
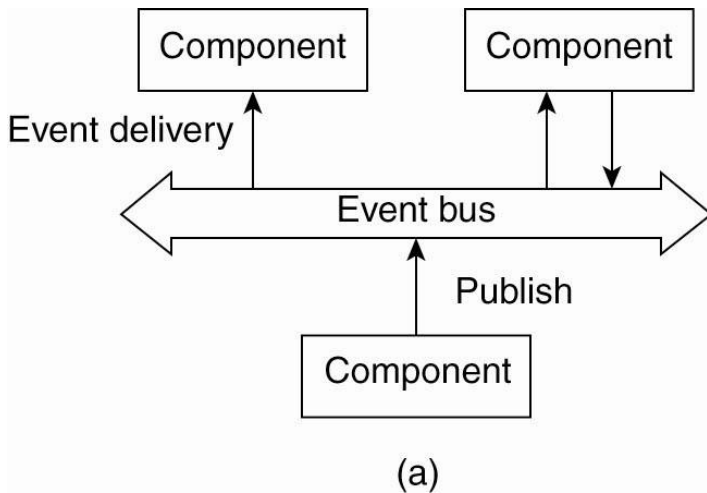
(a) Layered style is used for client-server system

(b) Object-based style for distributed object systems

Architectural Styles

Observation

Decoupling processes (“anonymous”) and removing time constraints (“asynchronous”) led to alternative styles



(a) Publish/Subscribe [**anonymous**]

(b) Shared dataspace [**anonymous and asynchronous**]

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